



Financial Planning For The Big Exit In IPO, M&A, Or Tender Offer



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FEATURED ARTICLE

A Guide To Restricted Stock Units (RSUs): Key Points You Must Know

By myStockOptions Editorial Team

Restricted stock units (RSUs) are the most common type of equity compensation granted by companies. While RSUs are a valuable benefit for employees, they require planning. You need to understand your vesting schedule, how taxes will be withheld at vesting, and what you will do with the shares after they are delivered, among other key points covered by this article.

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TAX CENTER: TAX CHANGES

How The 2025 Tax Law Affects Stock Options And RSUs

NEW! The "One Big Beautiful Bill" Act (OBBBA) made permanent many prior tax provisions but also brought a few surprises. In this article, we present expert insights from advisors on ways the OBBBA will affect your planning for equity comp and holdings of company shares.

RESTRICTED STOCK: RESTRICTED STOCK UNITS

6 Key Tax And Financial-Planning Strategies For RSUs

NEW! Restricted stock units (RSUs) are not as simple as they look. You need a plan for the taxes and the shares before the stock is delivered to you at vesting. In this article, three elite financial advisors reveal the strategies and topics they review with clients.

Webinar Presenters



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Webinar Agenda

- FILL IN Once deck complete

Section Break: Cleaning Up (And how to Prevent) a Post-Liquidity Mess



Types of Exits

- Tender Offer

- Investors or the company buy back shares from employees.
- Provides liquidity without a full company sale.
- Common in late-stage startups before IPO.

- IPO

- Company lists shares on the public market.
- Stock options can become publicly tradeable shares.
- Often includes a lock-up period before you can sell.

M&A

- Another company buys or merges with your employer.
- Stock options usually get cashed out or converted.
- Outcome depends on deal terms—can be lucrative, but varies

Tender Offer – Private Company

- What it means for employees (your clients)
 - Can sell up to 20% of their holdings (held shares, exercised stock options, and unexercised stock options)
 - They don't have to sell 20%, can sell any amount
 - May provide liquidity before IPO or acquisition (this may be their only shot)
 - Participation is usually optional, not required.
- Potential landmines
 - Selling and exercising the wrong shares (for example: selling shares they've held for less than 1 year)
 - Taxes are not withheld or underwithheld and client is hit with surprise tax bill
 - Possible impact on eligibility for incentive stock option (ISO) tax benefits.
 - Tax consequences (ordinary income vs. capital gains treatment).
 - missing the close date and not being able to participate (true story)



IPO– Private Company > Public Company

- What it means for employees (your clients)
 - Creates opportunities for diversification and cashing out.
 - May increase visibility and perceived value of equity compensation.
 - Develop a staged selling strategy (don't dump everything at once).
 - Coordinate with financial/tax advisors before exercising or selling

Potential landmines

- AMT trap: Employees who exercised Incentive Stock Options before IPO but didn't sell shares sometimes faced huge Alternative Minimum Tax (AMT) bills when the stock later tanked.
- When the 180-day lock-up expires, everyone rushes to sell, often crashing the stock price.
- Tax considerations: selling right after IPO may trigger high taxes (ordinary income vs. capital gains). Market risk: stock price can be very volatile after IPO. Concentration risk: keeping too much wealth tied to one stock.



M&A – Usually Private, Occasionally Public

Often employees have no say, are offered cash, shares in new company, and potentially a retention bonus

- **What it means for employees (your clients)**
- Creates opportunities for diversification and liquidity.
- May increase visibility and perceived value of equity compensation (especially when private company is now public)
- Understand deal terms: stock-for-stock vs. cash payout impacts strategy.
- Coordinate with financial/tax advisors before exercising or selling.

- **Potential landmines**
- A great case for hiring an advisor early who can model out long term capital gains vs short term (exercise options a year ahead of sale)
- Tax surprises: treatment of options/RSUs varies by deal structure.
- Accelerated vesting may push employees into higher tax brackets.
- Cash payouts can create withholding shortfalls or unexpected AMT issues.
- Concentration risk: if paid in acquirer's stock, wealth is still tied to one company.
- Emotional/financial uncertainty if roles are eliminated post-merger.

WATCH OUT FOR!

Misrepresented 409(a) valuations

Misclassified NQOs vs. ISOs

Double-trigger vesting mishaps (e.g. Figma)

RSUs vesting at IPO (e.g. Reddit case)

surprise
SURPRISE



QSBS considerations

- **What is QSBS?**
- Qualified Small Business Stock (IRC §1202) allows up to 100% exclusion of capital gains if you hold eligible shares for 5+ years.
- Incentivizes investment in start-ups
- Applies only to C-corps under \$50M gross assets at time of issuance.

Your value as an advisor:

- Flag QSBS eligibility early.
- START THE CLOCK! EXERCISE EARLY AND OFTEN
- Help clients document holding periods and prepare for possible legislative changes.

QSBS Updates – OBBBA 2025

- **Key Changes**
 - **Graduated holding period** (for stock acquired after July 4, 2025):
 - 3 years = 50% exclusion
 - 4 years = 75% exclusion
 - 5 years = 100% exclusion
 - **Exclusion cap increased:** \$10M → \$15M, with inflation adjustment.
 - **Gross asset limit raised:** \$50M → \$75M.
- **Why it matters for your clients**
 - More flexibility: partial exclusions if you exit before 5 years.
 - Higher thresholds make it easier for fast-growing companies to qualify.
 - Bigger lifetime gain exclusions for founders and early employees.

Case Study: QSBS

Planned Strategy

Early Exercise

Cost to exercise: $100,000 \times \$0.40 = \$40,000$.

Starts **QSBS clock** right away.

Tender Offer (Year 2)

Sells 20,000 shares at \$4.00 = **\$80,000 proceeds**.

Basis: $\$0.40 \times 20,000 = \$8,000$.

Taxable gain: \$72,000 (likely **long-term capital gain**, since held 2+ years, not full QSBS yet).

Importantly: this sale **funds liquidity** to cover taxes or diversify early.

IPO Exit (Year 6)

Remaining 80,000 shares sold at average \$25 = **\$2,000,000 proceeds**.

Basis: $\$0.40 \times 80,000 = \$32,000$.

Gain: **\$1,968,000**.

QSBS applies (held >5 years, C-corp under limits).

Result: up to **100% exclusion** of gain → effectively **\$0 federal tax** on nearly \$2M.

Total after-tax outcome:

≈ **\$2.08M** (tender proceeds + QSBS-protected IPO sale).

Do Nothing

No early exercise, no QSBS.

At IPO (Year 6), sells all 100,000 shares at \$25 = **\$2,500,000 proceeds**.

Exercise cost at sale: \$40,000.

Taxable gain: \$2,460,000.

Likely **ordinary income or short-term gain** on spread (depending on option type/timing).

Assume 40% combined effective tax = **\$984,000 taxes owed**.

Total after-tax outcome:

≈ **\$1.52M**.

Section Break: Emotional Aftermath of Liquidity Events



Clients' expectations vs. post-exit reality

- **Expectation:**
 - Big payout = instant freedom
 - Cash in hand, house paid off, early retirement
- **Reality:**
 - **Lock-up periods:** can't sell when you want
 - **Volatile stock price:** value swings daily
 - **Headline obsession:** net worth tied to market news
 - **Tax surprises:** AMT, capital gains, withholding gaps
 - Overwhelming choices and pressure to “get it right”
- **Advisor role:**

Refocus in the chaos. Bring clients back to their original goals. Create a staged, tax-efficient plan for liquidity.

Paralysis around “What now?” and shift in identity

- **How much is enough?** Struggling to define new goals after liquidity.
- **Work identity crisis:** Do I stay for the earn-out even if I hate the new culture?
- **Lifestyle drift:** Fear of overspending vs. pressure to “upgrade.”
- **Loss of direction:** Net worth has changed, but values and purpose may not feel aligned.
- **Advisor role:** Ground the numbers with a **trading plan**, then focus on rebuilding identity, purpose, and long-term planning.

Trading plans for concentrated positions

Why they matter:

Provide a *map* in the chaos of sudden wealth

Remove emotional decision-making from volatile markets

Turn a one-time windfall into sustainable cash flow

What they do for clients:

Reduce stress around lock-ups, stock swings, and “headline net worth”

Allow advisors to focus on bigger questions:

- Will you stay at the job through the earn-out?
- How much income do you need for your life goals?
- What does wealth mean for your identity and relationships?

Advisor role:

Trading plans handle the numbers. You help clients reframe their future.

Option Only

X

General Info

Name

1

Company

PRDEM

Type

ISO

Granted Shares

10,000

Grant Date

Jan 1, 2022

Strike Price

\$0.50

Expiration Date

Dec 31, 2032

Annual Summary

Year	Vested	Sold	Legacy	Avg Sale Price	Exercised	Bargain Element
2023	2,500	75	0	\$7.00	250	\$2,037.50
2024	2,500	175	0	\$75.00	250	\$18,625.00
2025	2,500	0	0	-	0	\$0.00

Snapshot

Vested

7,500

Unvested

2,500

Exercised

500

History

Q Search

X

+

Actions	Date	Action Type	Vest Lot	Exercise Lot	Sale Lot	Quantity	FMV	Proceeds	STCG	LTCG	Confirmed
											☐
 	3/1/2023	Exercise		E1		125	\$5.00				☒
 	6/1/2023	Exercise		E2		125	\$15.00				☒
 	9/1/2023	Sell		E1	S1	75	\$7.00	\$525	\$150		☒

Sudden wealth syndrome—burnout, overspending, disengagement

The 5-Step Plan for Handling Your New Wealth

Accept it

You're wealthy. Let that sink in.

Wait

Don't rush. Make a plan before you act.

Don't DIY

Hire an expert. Reddit is not a financial plan.

Pay your taxes

Get it over with, reduce stress, sleep better.

Do some good

Giving boosts happiness more than another gadget ever will.



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I'm Rich, Now What

By AJ Ayers, CFP, EA, CEP



What Is the Meaning of All This Money?

Section Break: Rebuilding the Balance Sheet & Core Portfolio



Rebuilding the Balance Sheet & Core Portfolio

- You may want to return to your onboarding process, everything is different after a liquidity event! ‘
 - How much cash?
 - Lifestyle creep
- Core portfolio building and diversification strategies
 - Come up with a target grounded in a dollar amount: e.g.: \$1,000,000 in core portfolio
- Trading plans for concentrated positions
- Holding cash vs. chasing real estate/PE opportunities

Frame for Long-term Financial security: Core and Satellite Portfolio

Core (foundation):

Broad, diversified investments (index funds, ETFs, bonds)

70–90% of portfolio

Provides stability and long-term growth

Satellite (extras):

Higher-risk, concentrated positions

Company stock belongs here

10–30% of portfolio

Carefully sized to avoid overexposure

Advisor role:

Protect clients' new wealth from *shiny but dangerous* alternative investments that can derail the plan

Keep the core strong, so the satellites don't pull the whole portfolio off course



Case Study: The “Tech-xit” - The Setup

The Setup

- Client: 48-year-old tech executive with \$10M net worth (70% in employer stock).
- Wants to leave corporate life to work in public service / nonprofit sector.
- Practical fears:
 - “What if my lifestyle isn’t sustainable?”
 - “Healthcare costs?”
 - “Am I really ready to walk away from a \$500K+ tech salary?”

The Strategy

- Systematic diversification: over 3 years, sold down \$6M of stock.
- Reinvested into:
 - \$4M diversified portfolio → long-term growth + retirement income.
 - \$1M liquidity reserve → 5 years of core living expenses.
 - \$1M DAF → tax offsets + philanthropic runway.
- Client takes public-sector job at \$60K salary (teaching + nonprofit role).
- Provides health insurance and a modest paycheck.
- Psychological benefit: meaningful work and sense of purpose.



Case Study: The “Tech-xit” - The Outcome

The Outcome

- Annual living needs = \$200K → covered by a mix of:
 - Portfolio withdrawals (~\$140K at 3.5% withdrawal rate).
 - Public-service income (\$60K).
- Client enjoys financial independence, secure healthcare, and fulfillment from public work.
- Huge relief: no longer feels dependent on single-stock risk or golden handcuffs.
- The Tech-xit works when concentrated wealth is converted into a diversified plan.
- Public-service income + healthcare provides structure and security, even after a 90% pay cut.



Decision Fatigue & The Advisor's Role

The issue: Clients oscillating between too many and too few actions

Solution:

- Introduce the “Legacy Position” to ground planning
- Structuring decisions over a 6–12-month timeline



The “Legacy Position” Concept

- If the client is anchored, start with what they are keeping, not what they are selling
- Decide what the legacy position will be 5-20% and build a trading plan around that
- Establishes a long-term hedge early on which gives you freedom to optimize the rest

Legacy

Legacy percent 20%	Legacy target 3,600	Current legacy 0
		Planned legacy 0

Exit Plan

Exit %	Year	Shares Sold	Shares Exercised	Exercise Cost	Net Tax Due	Expected Net Proceeds	Cash In	Cash Out	Cash Flow	Plan Cash Balance
0%	2023	75	250	\$125	\$0	\$363	\$525	\$125	\$400	\$0
1%	2024	195	280	\$185	\$0	\$12,933	\$13,245	\$185	\$13,060	\$0
21%	2025	3,730	3,470	\$6,940	\$256,961	\$495,264	\$466,250	\$263,901	\$202,349	\$302,349

Practical Tools & Takeaways:

Post-Exit Planning Workflow (6–12 months)

Month 1–3: Taxes, liquidity, immediate cash set-asides

Month 3–6: Revisit goals, evaluate company stock concentration, adjust portfolio

Month 6–12: Explore charitable giving, estate planning, long-term income streams

Advisor role: Keep clients grounded, revisit plan as market and identity shifts unfold

Practical Tools & Takeaways:

Exit Readiness Checklist

Before liquidity event:

- Review equity type (ISOs, NSOs, RSUs)
- Confirm tax exposure (AMT, capital gains, withholding)
- Establish a trading plan
- Identify immediate cash needs vs. long-term goals
- Coordinate with CPA + advisor

Income		2024	2025 - no plan	2 year exit	6 year exit	Tax Estimates 2025	
Wages, Salaries, Tips, Etc.	✓	\$0	\$300,000	\$300,000	\$300,000	Taxable Income	Tax Due
Interest	✓	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$300,000	\$76,052
Dividends	✓	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0		
Business Income	✓	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0		
RSU Income	✓	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$0		
Short Term Gain	✓	\$60	\$0	\$0	\$0		
Ordinary Income		\$110	\$300,000	\$726,810	\$464,082		
Long Term Capital Gain	✓	\$13,038	\$0	\$32,325	\$32,325		
Total Income		\$13,148	\$300,000	\$759,135	\$496,407		
Adjusted Gross Income		\$13,148	\$300,000	\$759,135	\$496,407		

Questions?





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Ally Jane (AJ) Ayers is a Co-Founder of Brooklyn Fi, a financial planning firm specializing in tech professionals and creatives. She's a CERTIFIED FINANCIAL PLANNER™, an Enrolled Agent, and a Certified Equity Professional known for making complex financial concepts accessible. Through her expertise in equity compensation and tax planning, she has helped numerous clients transform IPO windfalls into paths to financial independence. AJ is also a financial writer, speaker, and co-host of The Liquidity Event podcast and author of the Substack newsletter *Money Changes Everything*.



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Shane Mason (CPA, CFP®, CPWA®) is a Co-Founder of Brooklyn Fi. He started his career in Big Four accounting, but quickly realized that traditional financial services weren't built to serve the needs of young, creative professionals with real income and no one to call for help. That realization led to the launch of a boutique tax firm, which evolved into Brooklyn Fi, a national firm known for its technical depth, smart systems, and human-first advice. Shane's expertise spans both tax and financial planning, with a focus on building scalable processes for delivering high-quality advice. He is a frequent speaker at accounting and advisory industry conferences, where he shares insights on equity compensation, tax strategy, and building modern advisory firms.



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Bruce Brumberg has devoted most of his professional career to making complex legal and tax concepts understandable to people who do not enjoy reading the Internal Revenue Code and the securities laws. Bruce is the editor-in-chief and a co-founder of myStockOptions.com, the premier provider of web-based educational content, [CE courses](#), and tools on stock options, restricted stock, ESPPs, SARs, and performance shares. The site features a special [Tax Center](#) devoted to tax return topics. He runs another website (myNQDC.com, on nonqualified deferred comp), produced the *Think Twice* insider-trading-prevention videos (www.insidertradingvideos.com), and writes a popular and blog at Forbes.com. Bruce graduated from the University of Michigan and University of Virginia School of Law.

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Financial Planning For Stock Wealth Following The Big Exit In IPO, M&A, Or Tender Offer



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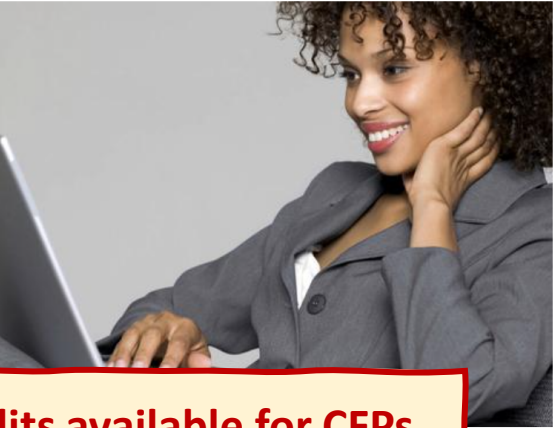
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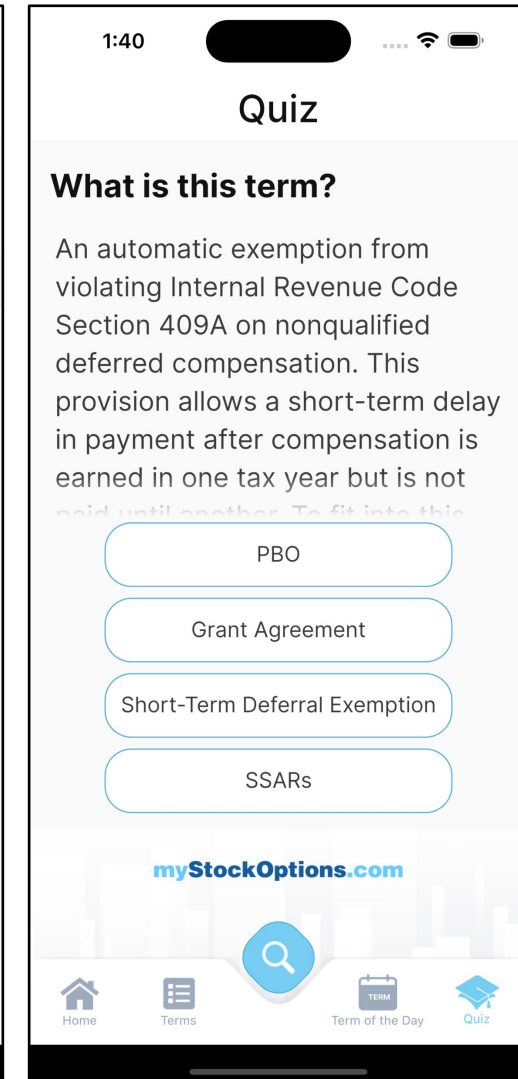
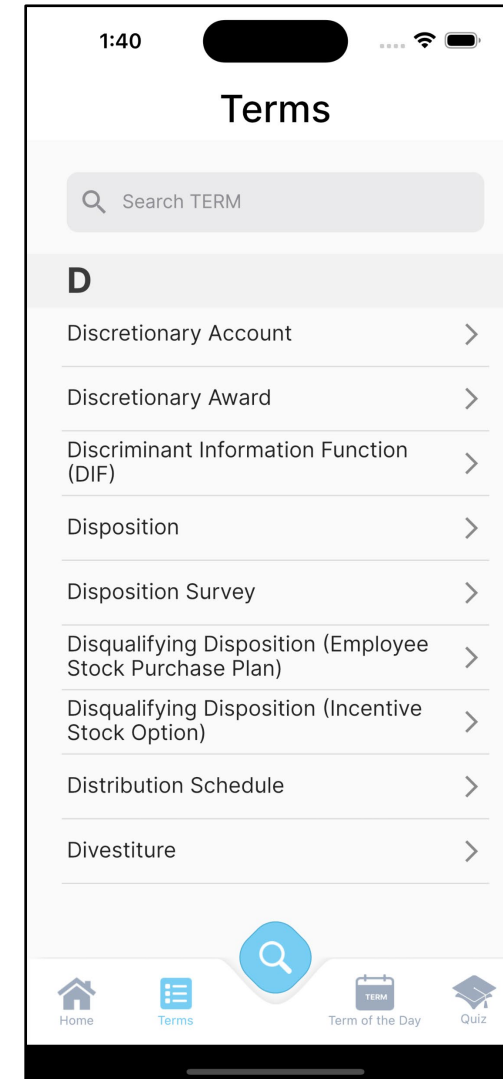
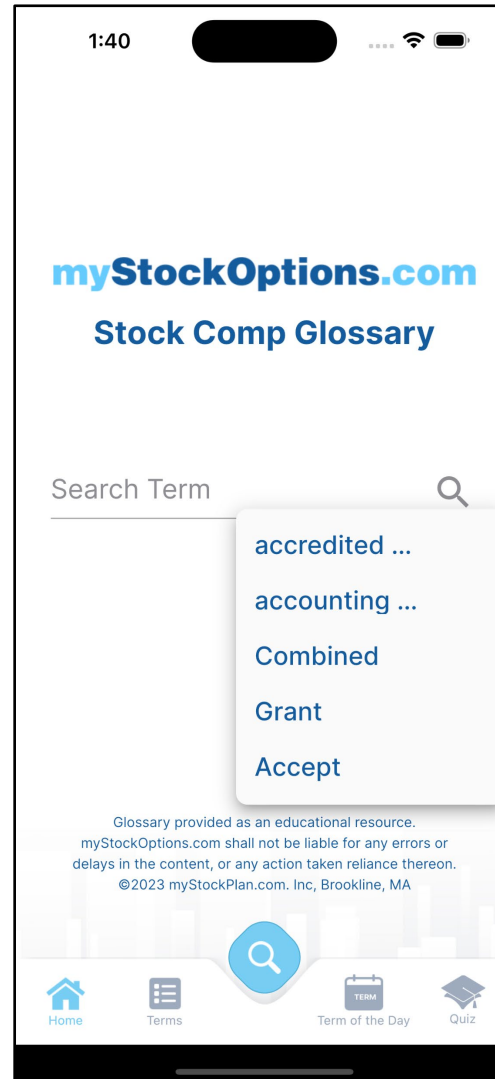
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Our other website myNQDC.com: resources on nonqualified deferred comp for financial advisors, companies, and plan participants.

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